

Canada



The second-largest country by area in the world, Canada has been independent since 1931.

900s–1000s The eastern coast of present-day Canada is explored and briefly settled by Norse explorers from Greenland.

1497–98 Italian navigator John Cabot explores the coast between Labrador and Chesapeake Bay.

1600s The exploration and settlement of Newfoundland and Québec is carried out.

1608 Québec City is founded.

1610 English Explorer Henry Hudson discovers Hudson Bay.

1629 English forces occupy the French stronghold of Québec City.

1632 Control of New France (the area around present-day Québec) and of Acadia (present-day Nova Scotia and New Brunswick) is granted to France by King Charles I of England.

1663 New France becomes a French Royal colony.

1713 Newfoundland and mainland Acadia are awarded to Britain under the terms of the Peace of Utrecht.

1743–48 King George's War: Britain captures French naval base at Louisbourg on Isle Royale, while French raid New York.

1755–63 The French and Indian War, the American equivalent of the Seven Years War, is concluded by the Treaty of Paris, which awards to Britain all French possessions in Canada except the islands of Saint Pierre and Miquelon off the coast of Newfoundland.

1758 The first elected legislative assembly in British North America meets at Halifax, Nova Scotia.

1774 Québec Act recognizes Roman Catholicism, and French language, culture, and traditions.

1775–83 During the American Revolution, Canada becomes a refuge for loyalists to British Crown.

1867 Federation of Canada is created under British North America Act, uniting Nova Scotia, New Brunswick, Québec, and Ontario.

1870 Manitoba joins the federation, followed by British Columbia in 1871 and Prince Edward Island in 1873.

1885 Transcontinental railroad completed.

1897 Klondike gold rush begins.

1914–18, 1939–45 Canada supports Allies in both world wars.

1931 Autonomy within British Commonwealth.

1949 Founding member of NATO. Newfoundland joins federation.

1968 Liberal Party under Pierre Trudeau in power. Separatist Parti Québécois (PQ) is formed to demand political separation from the federation with economic association.

1969 English and French made the official languages in Canada by the Official Languages Act.

1970s Extremist groups resort to violence to promote Québec's independence.

1976 In Québec, PQ wins elections.

1980 Separation of Québec rejected at referendum. Pierre Trudeau is prime minister again.

1982 UK transfers all powers relating to Canada in British law.

1984 Trudeau resigns. Elections won by Progressive Conservative Party (PCP); Brian Mulroney is prime minister until 1993.

1987 Meech Lake Accord on provincial–federal relationship. It was rejected in 1990.

1989 Canadian–US Free Trade Agreement.

1992 Charlottetown Agreement on provincial–federal issues rejected in a referendum. Canada, Mexico, and US finalize terms for North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA).

1993 Crushing election defeat of PCP, which now holds only two seats in parliament, and the rise of regional parties; Jean Chrétien leads Liberal government.

1994 PQ regains power in Québec. NAFTA takes effect.

1995 Narrow “no” vote in a second Québec sovereignty referendum.

1995 Fishing dispute with EU.

1997 Regional considerations again dominate federal elections; Liberals retain power; election victory based on support in Ontario.

1997 Calgary Conference establishes a Canadian unity framework and recognizes Québec's “unique character”; all provinces take part except Québec.

1997 Supreme Court ruling on land rights establishes the principle of “Aboriginal title,” opening the way for the return of all ancestral lands claimed by indigenous Canadian and Inuit nations.

1998 The federal government formally apologizes to Canadian Indians for past mistreatment.

1998 PQ only narrowly holds power in Québec.

1999 Nunavut gains the status of a territory, the first part of Canada to be governed by indigenous Inuits.

2000 Federal Clarity Act sets strict criteria for the validation of any pro-independence referendum.

2003 PQ ousted by Liberals in Québec after nine years in power. Chrétien stands down as federal prime minister in favor of Paul Martin.

2004 Early elections: Liberals again retain power, forming a minority government with the federal Bloc Québécois and New Democratic Parties.

2006 In the general election, the Liberals narrowly lose power after financial scandals in government; the newly revived Conservatives under Stephen Harper take power for the first time in 12 years.

2008 Stephen Harper's Progressive Conservative government is reelected.

«232–33 The Great Food Exchange
«434–35 Civil Rights

Mexico



A large, mostly Spanish-speaking nation that won independence from Spain in 1821.

c.1325 The Mexica (Aztecs) start construction of the city of Tenochtitlán (modern-day Mexico City) on Lake Texcoco. By the 15th century, the Aztec Triple Alliance of Tenochtitlán, Texcoco, and Tlacopán dominates the Valley of Mexico, and its power reaches the Pacific and Atlantic coasts.

1519–21 Hernán Cortés lands in Mexico and takes control of the Aztec empire ruled by Emperor Moctezuma.

1522 Cortés is named captain-general of Spanish-controlled American territories known as New Spain.

1535 The Viceroyalty of New Spain, incorporating the Captaincy-General, is established. By 1546 the Spaniards have discovered large silver mines at Zacatecas.

1808 The Viceroy of New Spain is ousted but the territory remains in royalist hands (supporting Ferdinand VII of Spain whom Napoleon had deposed) until 1821.

1810 Father Miguel Hidalgo leads abortive rising against Spanish.

1821 Spanish viceroy forced to leave by Mexican rebel Agustín de Iturbide, who is proclaimed emperor of Mexico.

1822 Federal Republic established.

1823 Texas opened to US immigration.

1830 Mexican troops fail to control increased immigration from the US.

1836 Texas declares its independence from Mexico and is recognized by the US and Spain.

1845 US annexes Texas.

1846 War breaks out with US following its annexation of Texas.

1848 Mexico loses modern-day New Mexico, Arizona, Nevada, Utah, California, and part of Colorado to the US by the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo.

1853 Mexico sells strip of land to the US in the Gadsden Purchase, allowing the US Southern Pacific Railroad to cross from Texas into southern California; the land now forms the southern part of Arizona and New Mexico.

1857–61 War of Reform won by anticlerical Liberals.

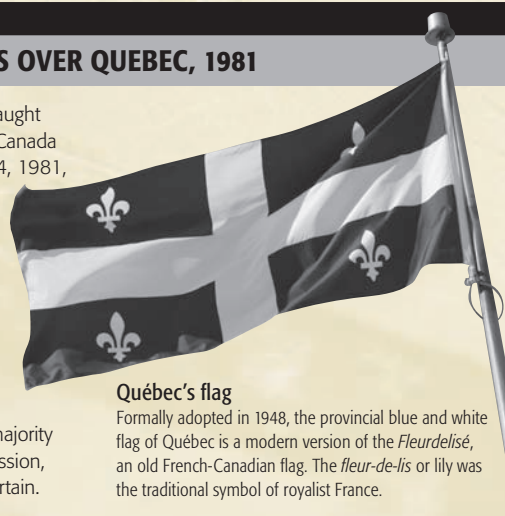
1862 France, Britain, and Spain launch military expeditions to Mexico.

1863 French troops capture Mexico City. Maximilian of Austria established as Mexican emperor.

DECISIVE MOMENT

CONSTITUTIONAL CRISIS OVER QUEBEC, 1981

French-speaking Québec's often-fraught relationship with English-speaking Canada reached a new low on November 4, 1981, when Prime Minister Pierre Trudeau met with every provincial premiere except Québec's René Lévesque to seek their signatures on a new Canadian constitution. Québec still hasn't signed the document, and 14 years later the Québécois rejected independence in a referendum by a 1 percent majority. For the first time a clear majority of French-speakers voted for secession, and Québec's future remains uncertain.



Québec's flag

Formally adopted in 1948, the provincial blue and white flag of Québec is a modern version of the *Fleurdelisé*, an old French-Canadian flag. The *fleur-de-lis* or lily was the traditional symbol of royalist France.